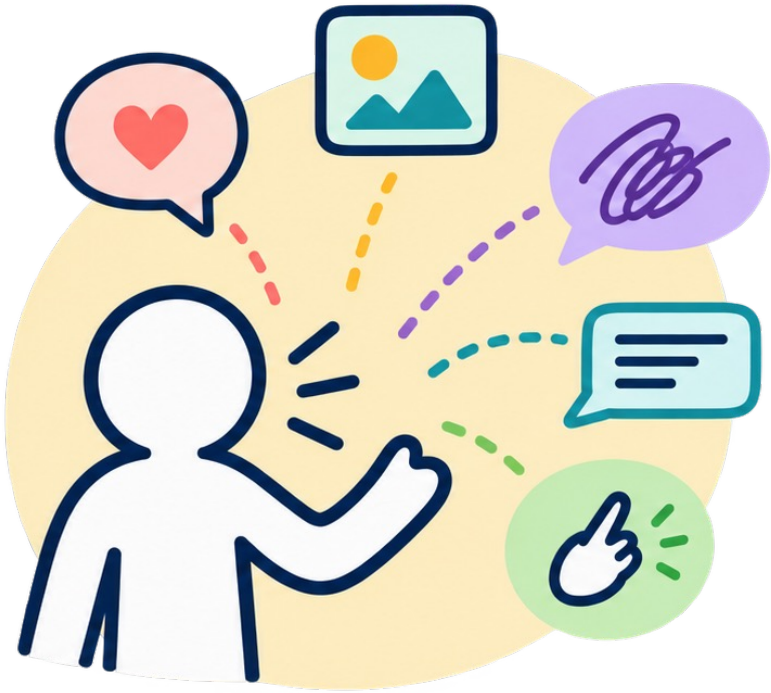




Education Support Staff · Session 3

Autistic Experience at School:

**Communication, Connection
and Identity**



Communication





Understanding and expressing

How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand.

Understanding

Information coming in

Spoken words



Visual or written



Demonstration



Gesture and context



Expressing

Messages going out

Speech



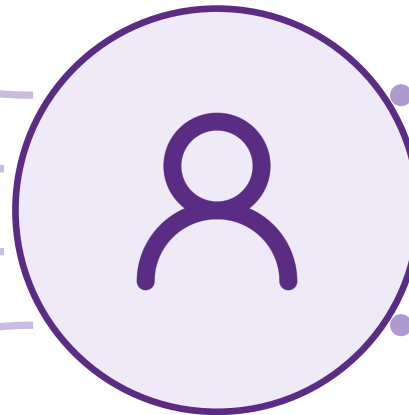
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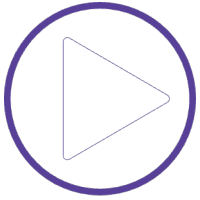


Writing or typing



Gesture, sign and movement





Communication experiences

What stood out to you about what supported communication?



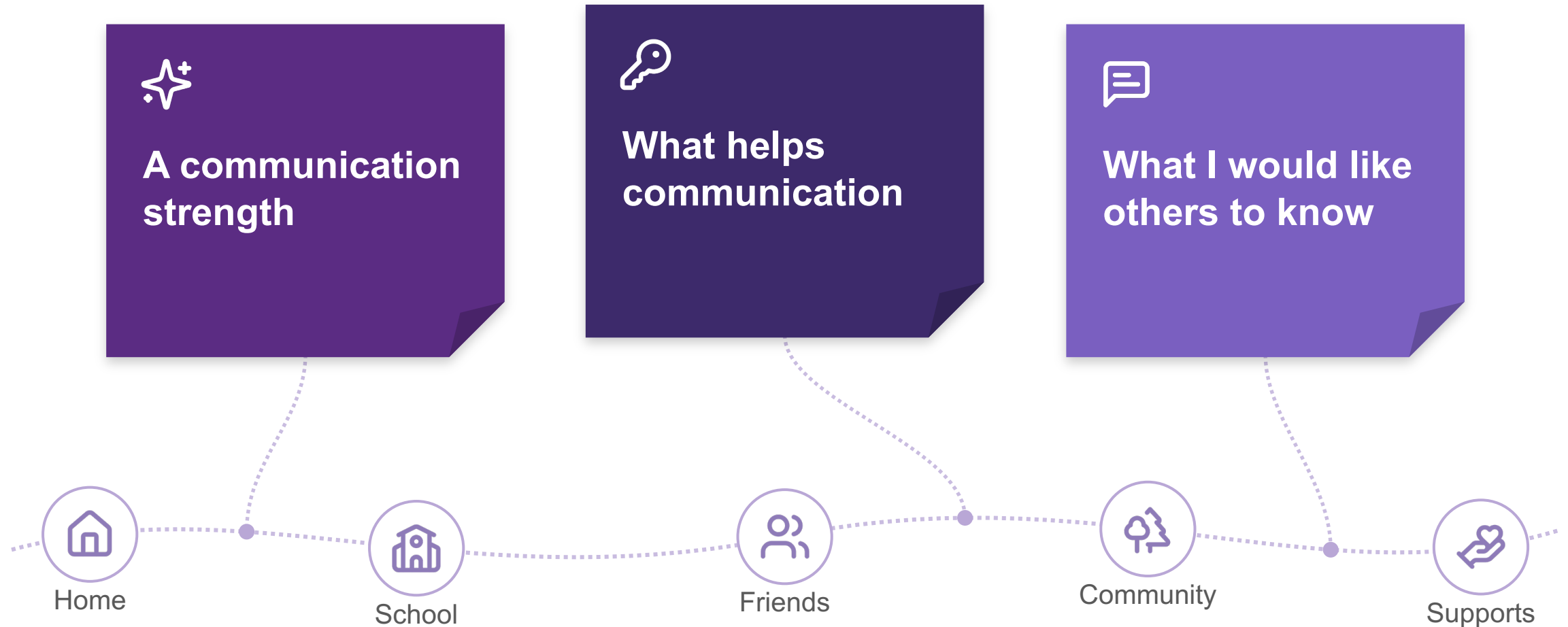
Who is part of the communication network?



Add one person or place.

You can return to the rest later.

What should travel between people and places?



How can we support communication?

1

CLEAR COMMUNICATION

Use familiar words.
One idea or step at a time.

2

PROCESSING TIME

Pause. Give time to
understand and respond.

3

VISUAL SUPPORTS

Show information as well
as saying it.

The right support depends on the person and the moment.

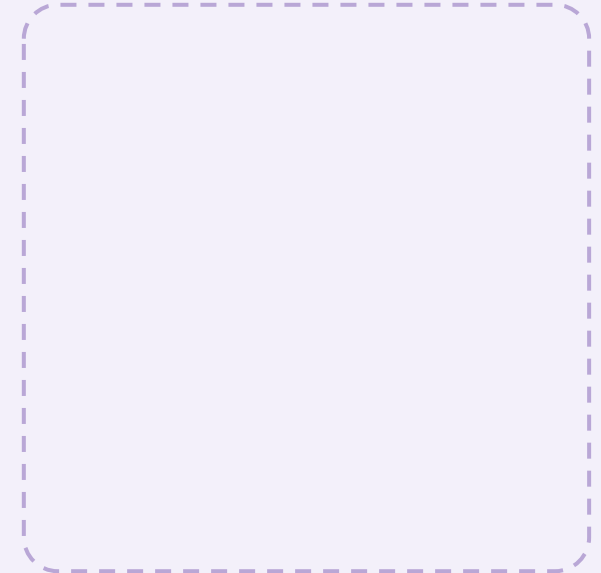
What are visual supports?



How much time is left?



What do I do next?

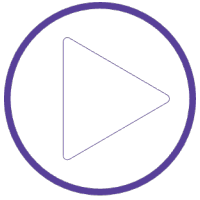


What is happening today?

Information you can see and come back to.

Double Empathy





Being social



Social Interactions

Family

School

Community

Online

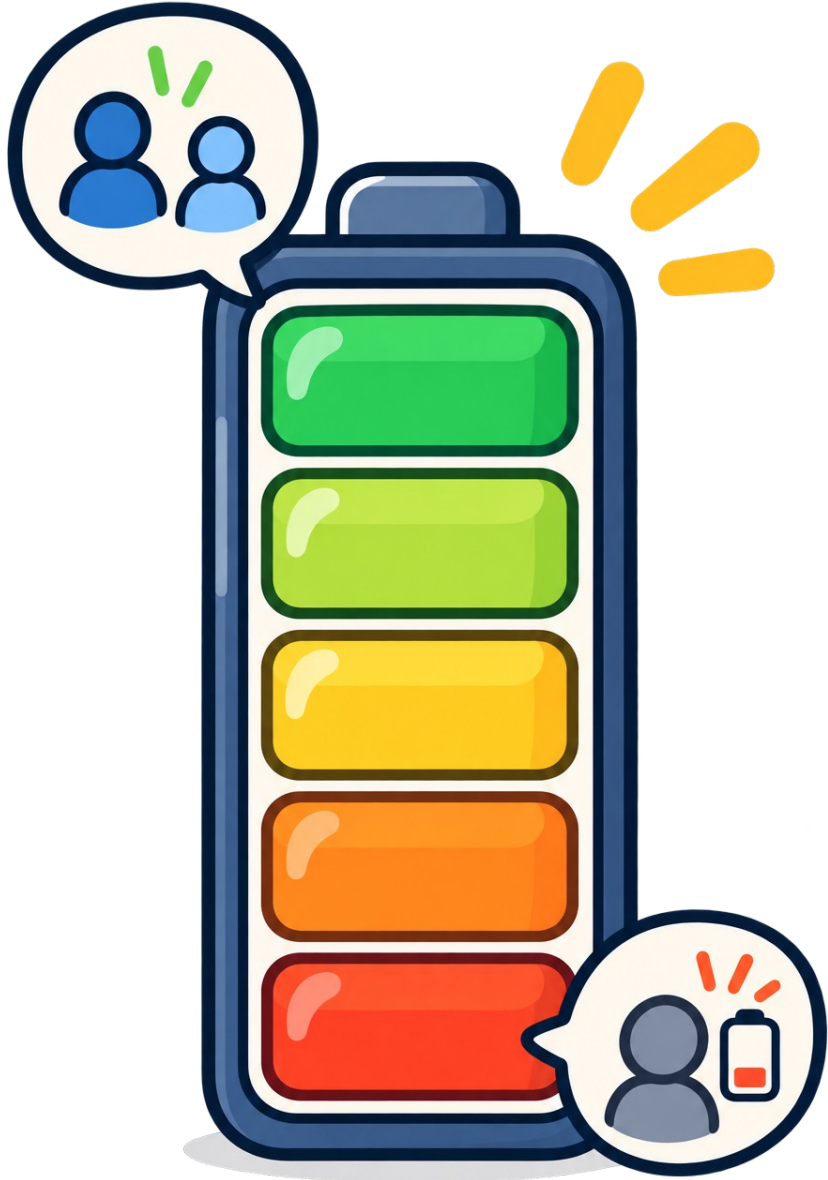


Discussion activity



- When do the students you have in mind seem most comfortable connecting with others at school?
- What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy?
(Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)
- Are there times in the school day when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?
- What can educators change to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?





Managing Daily Capacity

Batteries and Spoons

Think of a student's energy as a battery.

Every day starts with a charge amount, and it's not the same charge at the start of each day.

Every action uses up energy. When the battery runs low, the body will show it.



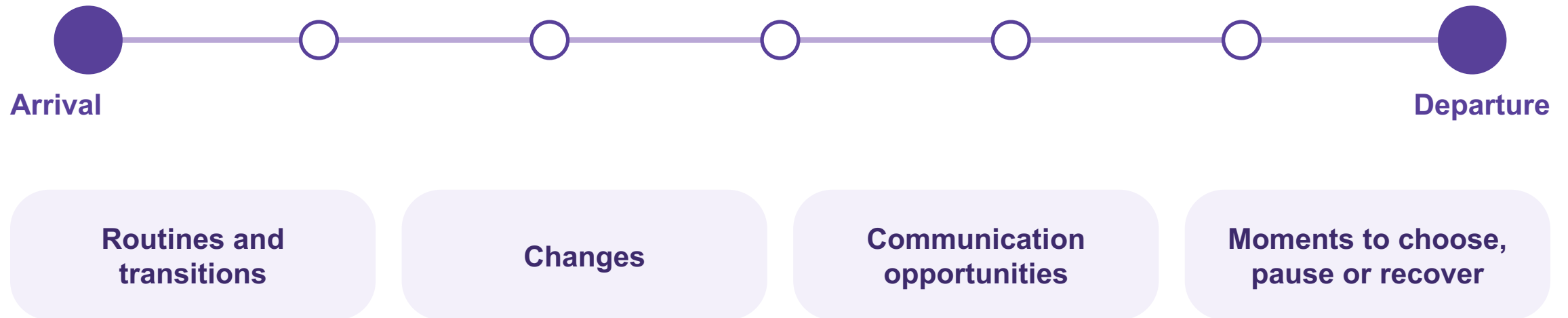
Fluctuating Capacity



Map a school day

Follow the day of a student you support, from arrival to departure.

Include every room and space they move through. Then mark how the same moments affect each of the students you have in mind.



What costs? What lightens?

Return to the day map.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand?

What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

Record questions rather than claiming to know an internal state.

The school-day stack

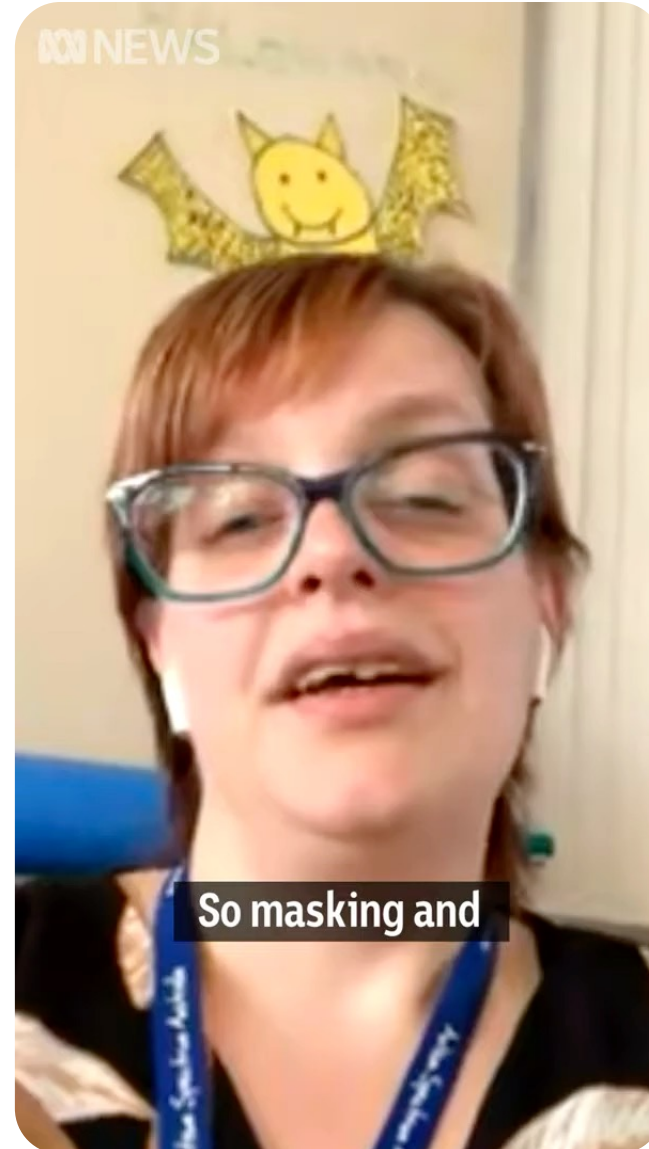
Notice what accumulates across the whole day.

A moment that seems small in isolation may sit within many demands. Include supports, relief and recovery as well as cost.





Masking



Masking and the cost of appearing fine



Discussion activity



- When might one of the students you have in mind be working hard to appear “fine” at school when they are not?
- When and where at school do they seem most comfortable being themselves?
- What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Observing and sharing what you see

You often see a student's day more closely than anyone else.

Early signs

You may notice changes before anyone else: going quiet, pressing harder, stiffening.

What, not why

Write what you saw and heard, and when. Keep guesses about feelings out of it.

Keep it short

Two lines is enough: the time, what happened before, and what helped.

Pass it on

Share it with the teacher, in the way your school agrees.

If you need to know something to support a student well, ask: 'What should I know?'

In the moment

When a student is overwhelmed, you are often the closest adult.

Fewer words

Speak quietly and say less. Language is hard to process under stress.

Space and dignity

Reduce the audience, give room, and stay where the student can find you.

Offer, don't demand

Offer a way out, water or a known calming tool as choices.

Afterwards

Recovery comes first. Then note what happened before and pass it on.

Follow your school's policies. This is support, not physical intervention.

Audit across settings

Follow one student through five settings. What changes at each move, and why?

- 1 Name the setting or the move between settings.
- 2 Write what educators can observe without interpretation.
- 3 List possible environmental or task contributors.
- 4 Record what lightens demand and one question to investigate.

Settings to look at:

The classroom · a specialist lesson · the playground or yard · the library or canteen · the corridors and moves in between.

Carry into design

Choose a clear focus for the next session.

Keep

One support to keep
because it helps
access, connection or
joy

Reduce

One barrier or
unnecessary demand to
reduce

Explore

One question to explore
with the student, the
teacher or the family

Keep students first.

Positive Autistic Identity

A student who knows who they are
- and feels genuinely valued for it -
has more available for everything
else.

